Xiaofeng Gong

Ph.D. Candidate in Economics | Department of Economics, University of Connecticut
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Updated: November 2026

Research Fields

Primary: Industrial Organization; Economics of Innovation; Digital Economy; Intellectual Property; Open-Source Software
Secondary: Political Economy; International Economics; Media Economics; Law and Economics; Industrial Policy; Economics of Crime; Strategic Technologies
Methods: Applied microeconomic theory; dynamic models; computational equilibrium methods; applied microeconometrics; survival and hazard analysis; LLM-assisted data construction

Education

University of Connecticut, Department of Economics
Ph.D. in Economics, 2022-present; expected May 2027
Dissertation: *Zero-Price Intellectual Properties and Profit-Oriented Firms*
Advisor: Talia Bar. Dissertation committee: Talia Bar, Ling Huang, Mike Shor, and Stephen L. Ross.
Dissertation proposal approved April 2026.

London School of Economics and Political Science
M.Sc. in Economics, 2020-2022

University of Connecticut
B.S. in Mathematics and Economics, 2016-2020; double major; Honors in Economics

Publications

Zhong, Chunping, and **Xiaofeng Gong**. 2023. "Economic and Financial Sanctions: Academic Progress and Disputes" [经济金融制裁研究的进展与争议]. *Russian, East European & Central Asian Studies*, no. 1: 12-34. DOI: 10.20018/j.cnki.reecas.2023.01.002.

Zhong, Chunping, Yuechuan Zhao, and **Xiaofeng Gong**. 2026. "Why Is It Difficult for Sanctions to Achieve Their Intended Goals? Evidence from the Global Sanctions Database" [制裁为什么难以达成预设目标？——来自全球制裁数据库的宏观经济效应证据]. *Eurasian Economy*, no. 3: 50-73.

Job Market Paper

Cathedrals Opening Bazaars: Firms' Open-Source Projects and Community Participation. Solo-authored. Job market paper; version of November 6, 2026. This paper studies how participation in firms' open-source projects relates to the technologies the firms patent. I link Compustat firms to their USPTO patents and GitHub accounts and use a large language model to place each project in the Cooperative Patent Classification, the scheme patent examiners use. I document that most of these projects lie in technologies in which the firm was recently granted patents. I then compare projects first active in 2015–2022, conditional on firm-by-year and technology-by-year effects and on controls for each project's early activity, text and language. I find that projects in the firm's patented technologies have more new participants and more contributions from them. The difference in new participants holds for people with no earlier activity on the firm's GitHub accounts and without the five largest firms. Contributions from everyone are also higher, and among projects with a contribution there is no clear difference in new participants' share. According to my estimates, projects in the firm's patented technologies have 29.5 percent more new participants in the 24 months after their first active quarter, 45.5 percent more contributions from them, and 37.6 percent more contributions from everyone.

Working Papers

The Ethnic Composition of Inventors in Entrepreneurial Firms. With Talia Bar and Delia Furtado. Submitted to the *Handbook of Research on Immigration and Entrepreneurship*. Examines the representation of Chinese and Indian inventors on patents awarded to young U.S. firms and discusses how early-career visa constraints may help explain their underrepresentation.

When Open-Source and Proprietary Innovation Suppress Each Other. Solo-authored. Work in progress. Develops a dynamic quality-ladder model linking proprietary pricing, decentralized open-source contribution, and investment incentives.

Strategic Ignorance in Media Markets: Unauthorized Distribution and Foreign Entry. Solo-authored. Work in progress. Studies foreign media entry with endogenous copyright enforcement and unauthorized pre-entry distribution as an audience-building channel.

Why Do Sanctions Persist? Rents and Endogenous Domestic Political Power. With Yuechuan Zhao and Chunping Zhong. Submitted to *Comparative Economic Studies*. Develops a dynamic public-choice model of why comparable external sanctions generate persistent noncompliance in some target countries but not in others.

Do Subsidies Work When Technology Access Is Restricted? A Schumpeterian Model of Strategic-Sector Industrial Policy. With Chunping Zhong. Work in progress. Studies how restrictions on foreign technology access change the return to domestic research support in a two-country growth economy.

LLM agent based model for Least-Pressure Sanctions Politics. With Ziwei Wang (first author). Work in progress. Builds a single-country agent-based model in which households and firms are run by a large language model and respond to sanctions through their beliefs, saving, pricing, and input sourcing, and applies it to Russia from February to April 2022.

Measuring Racial Disparities in Police Stops: Evidence from Telemetric Mobility Data. With Yuling Han, Susan Parker, Matthew B. Ross, and Stephen L. Ross. Submitted to the *Quarterly Journal of Economics*. NBER Working Paper 35727. NBER Economics of Crime Working Group conference paper.

Research Experience

Research Assistant, Telemetric Data Project, Stephen L. Ross
Department of Economics, University of Connecticut | September 2023-present
Data cleaning, regression programming, empirical implementation, and mathematical and statistical calculations.

Research Assistant, Connecticut Bail Bond Project, Stephen L. Ross
Department of Economics, University of Connecticut | September 2025-present
Data cleaning, court-record construction, and regression analysis.

Additional Experience (Undergraduate)

Intern, China Development Bank (Headquarters, Beijing) | June-August 2017
Participated in Belt and Road-related research; hosted visiting delegations from foreign development banks and participated in related conferences.

Quantitative Trading Development Intern, CICC Quantitative Fund program, Renmin University of China | July-August 2018
Participated in the development of quantitative trading systems.

Grants and Funding

Art Wright Fund Research Grant, University of Connecticut | 2026 — $2,675 for *Open-Source Engagement, IP Alignment, and Investor Signals*, under the supervision of Professor Talia Bar.

Graduate Assistantship and Tuition Waiver, University of Connecticut | 2022-present; **Eleanor Bloom Funding, Department of Economics, University of Connecticut** | Annual award, 2022-present.

Teaching Experience

Instructor of Record, ECON 1201 Principles of Microeconomics, University of Connecticut | Fall 2025
Enrollment: 60. Median student evaluation: 4.0/5.0.

Instructor of Record, ECON 1202 Honors Principles of Macroeconomics, University of Connecticut | Spring 2026
Enrollment: 14. Median student evaluation: 4.0/5.0 (3 of 14 students responded).

Presentations and Conferences

NBER Economics of Crime Working Group Meeting | Spring 2026 — *Measuring Racial Disparities in Police Stops: Evidence from Telemetric Mobility Data* on program; coauthor presented; attended.

Research Tools

Programming and formal methods: Python; Stata; R; MATLAB; Lean 4; LaTeX
Data construction and reproducibility: Schema-constrained LLM workflows; automated data labeling and verification; API-based data pipelines; testing, provenance, and source registries
Research data and platforms: WRDS (Compustat, CRSP, I/B/E/S); LSEG Workspace; GitHub API; GH Archive; USPTO; GSDB; WDI

Languages

Mandarin Chinese; English

References

Department of Economics, University of Connecticut.

- **Talia Bar** (Advisor)
- Ling Huang
- Owen Svalestad
- Stephen L. Ross